

# Red-eyed tree frog

*Agalychnis callidryas*

The red-eyed tree frog is an iconic rainforest amphibian. As its name suggests, it has striking red eyes, although these are usually hidden from view. To camouflage itself against leaves, it makes itself look small by tucking its legs against the body so that only the green upper surfaces are in view. The eyes are shut to conceal the telltale red irises. When a predator gets too close, the frog flashes its eyes wide open, startling it momentarily. As it leaps to safety, extending its legs to a full stretch, it reveals yet more hidden color on its flanks and thighs.

## Agile climber

The red-eyed tree frog is a nocturnal insect hunter. The vertical diamond shape of its iris shows that it is focused on tracking the vertical movements of insects marching up and down tree trunks. Like all frogs, the tree frog is

a good jumper, but it also climbs up trees, gripping branches with the suction cups at the tips of its fingers and toes. Unlike most frogs, the red-eyed tree frog can swim, although the adult spends most of its life in trees. It visits water regularly—often just the puddles formed on leaves—to absorb water through the thin skin on its belly.

## Show of strength

Mating takes place in the rainy season. Males, who adopt prominent perches, initiate courtship through a croaking call. They also quiver their body so much that the surrounding leaves begin to shake. This show of strength attracts females, and when one gets near, all the males in the area fight to mate with her. The winner fertilizes her egg clutches as she lays them on leaves in several batches.

## ► FLASH COLORING

The bright blue and yellow flanks of the red-eyed tree frog are only visible when the frog is on the move. The flash of color startles predators as the frog makes a hasty escape.

bright green upper body  
provides camouflage

orange feet hidden  
when at rest

distinctive blue  
and yellow markings  
on sides

